

The door creaked open, and a soft light spilled in. It was Khalid, Zayd's father. He didn't ask what was wrong or tell Zayd to go to bed.

Instead, he walked over and sat down on the rug beside his son. Khalid's presence was like a warm blanket, steady and calm.

He waited until Zayd's breathing finally slowed before he spoke, his voice a gentle murmur in the still night air.